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Ethics Component

Although this project does not gather data directly from individuals or communities, it is still important to review ethical concerns. The data gathered for this project comes from the USBR and Copernicus Climate Data Store, which publicly publish data regarding the Colorado River and precipitation respectively. The usage of this data is for academic purposes, which both databases allow.

The largest ethical concern surrounding this project is the effect the results could potentially have on communities and industries that use the river's water. Although unlikely, the results from this project may show that water consumption should need to be greatly reduced during periods of low precipitation, possibly resulting in policy that forces people and businesses to use drastically less water. Limiting water usage could result in reduced agricultural production and higher water costs for residences and industry.

The best way to address this ethical concern is by presenting different ways in which water can be managed to produce the same economic or agricultural output. Different ways can include shifting from water intensive irrigation, expanding water treatment plants, and rainwater catching infrastructure.